

CASE STUDY

Designing Mindful Money Habits

A six-week lean UX sprint to validate the concept of a spending journal called SpendLight

Industry Personal Finance

Year 2025

Role UX research, concept validation, UX design, prototype testing

Timeline 6 weeks

Outcome Validated product strategy and a clear, buildable MVP

Project Snapshot

A founder and former colleague approached me with an early idea for a "spending journal" to improve discretionary spending habits. The concept was promising but lacked design direction or validation. In six weeks, I transformed his idea into a validated product direction, a mindful journaling flow, and a complete Minimum Viable Product (MVP) specification ready for engineering.

The Core Experience: SpendLight's Journaling Loop

To make journaling about discretionary spending effortless, I designed a fast, calming flow built around three principles: minimal friction, emotional clarity, and positive reinforcement. The flow goes from onboarding to a mood check-in, logging a purchase reflection, capturing context, and receiving encouragement through the bonsai micro-animation.

The Problem

Traditional budgeting tools focus on categorization and control, which often triggers guilt and avoidance. The people I interviewed were not looking for stricter budgets — they wanted emotional awareness around their discretionary spending.

The founder's hypothesis: a spending journal could help people spend more mindfully, just like food journaling aids weight loss. To validate this, we needed to know:

- Will people actually log discretionary spending manually?
- Does reflective journaling provide emotional value?
- What is the simplest possible version worth building?

My Approach

I structured the sprint around rapid discovery and MVP definition, ensuring we were validating while designing.

Weeks 1–2 — Understand & Explore

- Screener survey + four 1:1 interviews on spending habits
- SpendLight landing page messaging test setup
- First AI prototype (Figma Make) exploring a quick and easy reflection flow

Weeks 3–4 — Shape & Refine

- Explore journal prompting ideas
- IA + core habit loop definition
- A/B testing of "Find Your Calm" vs "Your Spending Is a Story" as value propositions

Week 5 — Test & Learn

- Two moderated usability tests with AI prototype
- Iterations on clarity, motivation, and journal entry flow

Week 6 — Synthesize & Deliver

- Synthesis into a validated product direction
- Full MVP spec, annotated design package, event schema for engineering

Constraints & Tradeoffs

No bank linking

Focused on discretionary purchases, intentionally excluding bank linking to reduce friction and privacy risk. Yet early feedback was clear: "I don't want to have to input all my transaction data!"

Discretionary focus

Chose not to support full expense tracking to avoid recreating budgeting fatigue. This narrowed the journaling experience but improved clarity.

Six-week timeline

Opted for parallel validation of messaging + prototype, requiring iterative decisions with incomplete data.

Scope tradeoffs

Analytics, social features, and in-depth coaching were intentionally excluded from MVP to keep the experience focused and buildable.

What Research Revealed

Journaling works, but only when the purpose is explicit

Without context, the app felt too open-ended. Clarifying the focus on discretionary spending became central to onboarding.

"If it feels like work, I'm not gonna do it."

"Typing into Notes becomes a job I don't want to do."

Design implication: Minimal reflection-first flow with optional details only.

Encouragement, not judgment

People wanted context and interpretation — not budgeting alarms or scolding.

"I want an AI coach I can tell everything to, and it helps me understand what's essential."

"Just show me what changed this month."

Design implication: Inspired the bonsai growth reward — the emotional anchor of the app's home screen.

Money is emotional

Participants linked money to mood, self-worth, and family roles. Emotional triggers disproportionately shaped financial decisions.

"Money is emotional as much as it is numerical."

"When it's the last days before payday I'm like AAAAH constant anxiety."

Design implication: Use warm, non-judgmental language and reflection prompts that normalize emotion.

Awareness over budgets

Participants rejected prescriptive budget styles. They wanted to understand patterns without being judged.

"I know some people have a specific amount they can spend on food. That would stress me out."

"I want to know if I'm living below my means."

Design implication: Prioritize awareness snapshots over prescriptive budgets.

Research Methodology

Interviews

Four 45–60 min interviews with people frustrated by budgeting apps:

- Household manager
- Small-business owner managing mixed cash + Venmo expenses
- Non-US young adult overwhelmed by micro-spending
- FIRE enthusiast with established tracking systems

Competitive Audit: Evaluated budgeting, journaling, and AI coaching apps for onboarding friction, data connections, logging flows, tone of voice, and how they handled emotional aspects of money. Key patterns leveraged: immediate insight loop and frictionless single-screen capture.

Information Architecture & Core Experience

SpendLight needed to support a daily reflection habit without feeling like a budgeting tool. Primary screens:

- **Home:** Bonsai, emotional anchor, entry point for reflection or mood check-in
- **Reflection Flow:** Choose to reflect on a Purchase or a No-Spend day
- **History:** Feed + calendar to review past reflections
- **Insights:** Pattern cards revealed after enough entries

Core Loop: Add reflection → add emotional context → receive bonsai growth feedback → review patterns in Insights.

Testing & Iteration

I conducted two moderated usability tests using my high-fidelity prototype.

What Worked:

- Reflection prompts felt meaningful and calming
- Emotional framing resonated immediately
- Bonsai animation provided gentle motivation and a delight factor

What We Improved:

- **Purpose clarity:** Reworked onboarding to emphasize discretionary focus
- **Tag complexity:** Kept tags optional to reduce cognitive load
- **No-spend days:** Created a dedicated flow so users felt rewarded even when they spent nothing
- **Celebration pacing:** Slowed bonsai animation for better emotional impact
- **Insights visibility:** Added insight cards directly to the feed with a calendar picker

Key Testing Insight: Mindfulness works, but only when "why am I logging this?" is unmistakable. This learning shaped the final narrative, tone, and microcopy throughout the app.

Outcome

The six-week sprint delivered a validated product strategy and a complete MVP specification. Research confirmed that the spending journal concept was desirable when scoped to discretionary purchases and framed around emotional awareness rather than budget control.

- Validated product direction backed by user research
- Full MVP specification ready for engineering
- Annotated design package with event schema
- A/B tested value propositions with a clear winner
- Usability-tested prototype with two rounds of iteration

Testimonial

"Vanessa functioned as an invaluable partner to help take a lot of scattered concepts and really develop a cohesive product concept for SpendLight. While I came to the table with a ton of possible directions, Vanessa brought us to that necessary point of convergence."

Right from the outset Vanessa was organized and methodical about our scheduled meetings and action items. She initiated and conducted several prospective user interviews, leading to important insights about the key features of our spending journal concept. Armed with that

perspective, she built out several functioning prototypes so that we could run through the key user experiences.

Vanessa's work was always timely and thorough, and working asynchronously was never a problem. She was always an attentive listener, and very quickly I felt like each of our ideas were stacking one upon another. From the first day, she felt like a true partner in our project.

I very highly recommend Vanessa to any organization in need of excellent product development work. She functions well in the trenches and is able to surface the right conversations to decision makers to keep things moving without spending an inordinate time in the weeds. And all of this is wrapped in an outstanding work ethic and cheerful demeanor."

— David Larsen, Founder, SpendLight